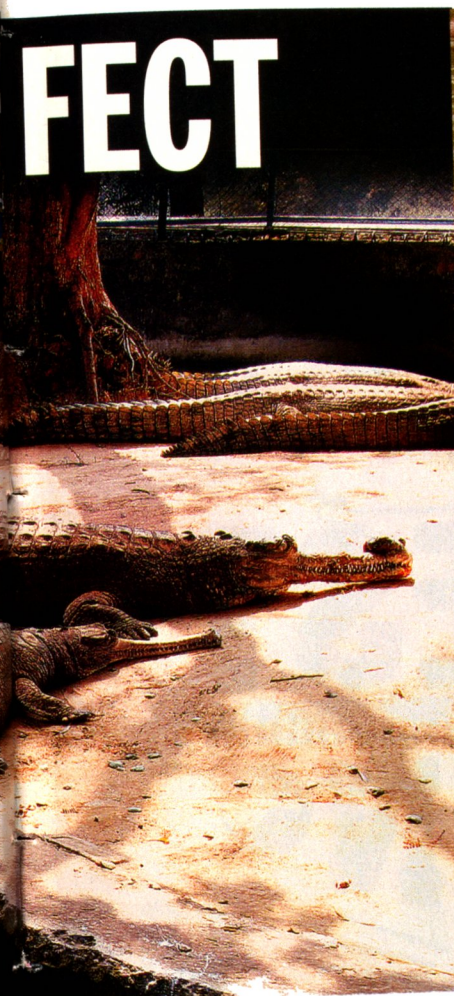


FECT



PROBLEM OF PLENTY

■ There has been an 11-fold rise in gharial population at the Patna zoo since 2002. The zoo can accommodate only 45 but has to house 130 reptiles.

■ The Patna zoo has also offered gharials to other zoos under an animal-exchange programme.

■ State authorities have decided to ease the pressure by releasing some reptiles in the Gandak river of West Champaran district.

■ The worry is that gharials bred in captivity lack the skills to survive in the wild. Accustomed to being spoon-fed fish, they are incapable of catching live prey.

■ The reptiles are also in danger from poachers for their valuable skin and male snouts, which are considered to be aphrodisiac.

SPOILT: The gharials at Patna zoo are undermined by their stay in captivity

would also expose them to poachers. Gharial eggs are often collected for medicinal purposes and males hunted for their snouts, assumed to have aphrodisiac properties.

It's not as if the authorities at the zoo are oblivious to the dangers involved. Says Kumar, "Although a decision to shift the gharials into river Gandak in April has already been taken, we are exploring other options. These include the shifting of the reptiles to other zoos across the country."

Earlier in December 2006, six gharials were shifted to Indira Gandhi Zoological Park at Visakhapatnam in an exchange programme that saw the Patna zoo getting sloth bears in return. According to Kumar, zoo authorities in

Thiruvananthapuram too have shown some interest to this effect. Says the director, "We have initiated a dialogue towards a possible exchange with them. Since gharials are Schedule 1 animals we need to have a clearance from the Central Zoo Authority before going for an exchange."

This exchange, if it takes place, would see a few more gharials transferred but will not lessen the congestion at the Patna zoo. Kumar also admits that they have no plans to construct more enclosures for the gharials in their zoo. He says, "We cannot show just gharials to visitors."

The zoo authorities, unfortunately, do not have any adaptation programme to ease the transition for the teeming numbers of reptiles. In fact, captive breeding and a controlled

environment have made the gharials in Patna zoo so dependent on the staff that they actually wait for them to dig up nests for them to lay their eggs. Usually nesting takes place in the dry, low-water season from March to May. Gharials are hole-nesters, so they excavate an egg chamber in the sandy banks above the flood line and deposit more than 40 eggs into the hole before carefully covering it up. The eggs, the largest of any crocodilian species, weigh an average of 160 gram each. They are hatched for 83 to 94 days, after which the brood emerges. Says Kumar, "Their dependency on the zoo staff is one huge difference between the gharials in the zoo and the reptiles who live in natural habitats." It is another matter that the authorities use this as a way of controlling population. Says the director, "We control their breeding by not digging the earth for the gharials. This leaves their eggs unprotected and weak, thus unworthy of hatchlings."

While the burgeoning gharial population at the zoo may be a burden for the authorities, for conservationists it is an extremely welcome sign because it has surfaced after the sudden and still unexplained deaths of the gharials in the National Chambal Sanctuary. The gharial is categorised as "critically endangered" under Schedule 1 of the Indian Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972 and conservationists believe there are only around 1,500 gharials left in the wild in India, many of them in the Chambal sanctuary. Experts believe the gharials may have become sick and died after eating contaminated fish from the polluted waters of river Yamuna, which joins the Chambal in Uttar Pradesh.

Although the experts are yet to reach a conclusion on the exact reason for these deaths, a host of factors including toxic fish and the presence of heavy metals in the river water are understood to be collectively responsible for the deaths of the reptiles.

Assurances by Sahni notwithstanding that all precautions would be taken before releasing the Patna gharials, fears over their safety remain. The optimism of conversationists over the re-emergence of the gharial in captivity is, thus, offset by their pessimism over its viability in the wild. ■